

Sensory Strategies

Sensory sensitivities – things to look out for:

Hypersensitive	Hyposensitive
• dislikes dark and bright lights • looks at minute particles, picks up smallest pieces of dust • covers ears • dislikes having their haircut • resists touch • avoids people • runs from smells • moves away from people • craves certain foods • uses tip of tongue for tasting • places body in strange positions • turns whole body to look at something • difficulty walking on uneven surfaces • becomes anxious or distressed when feet leave the ground	• moves fingers or objects in front of the eyes • fascinated with reflections, brightly coloured objects • makes loud rhythmic noises • likes vibration • likes pressure, tight clothes • enjoys rough and tumble play • smells self, people and objects • seeks strong odours • mouths and licks objects • eats anything • rocks back and forth • lack of awareness of body position in space • spins, runs round and round • bumps into objects and people

Sound



If someone is under-sensitive (hyposensitive) to sound- You could help by using [visual supports](#) to back up verbal information, and ensuring that other people are aware of the under-sensitivity so that they can communicate effectively. You could ensure that the experiences they enjoy are included in their sessions, to ensure this sensory need is met.

If someone is over-sensitive (hypersensitive) to sound- You could help by:

- shutting doors and windows where possible to reduce external sounds or positioning the person away from doors and windows
- planning your session to avoid the busiest times and/ or preparing the person before going to noisy or crowded places
- providing ear plugs and music to listen to

Touch



Under-sensitive- You could help by:

- for chewing, offering latex-free tubes, straws, or hard sweets (chill in the fridge).

- for smearing of faeces, offering alternatives to handle with similar textures, such as jelly, or cornflour and water

Over-sensitive- You could help by:

- allowing the person to wear clothes they are comfortable in.
- turning clothes inside out so there is no seam, removing any tags or labels
- be aware that certain types of touch may be unpleasant or painful, always warning the person if you are about to touch them - always approach them from the front
- remembering that a hug may be painful rather than comforting
- allowing a person to complete activities themselves (e.g. hair brushing and washing) so that they can do what is comfortable for them
- gradually introducing different textures to touch, e.g. have a box of materials available
- slowly introducing different textures around the person's mouth, such as a flannel, a toothbrush, and some different foods
- changing the texture of food (e.g. purée it)

Sight



Under-sensitive- Ways you might help include the use of [visual supports](#) or [coloured lenses](#), although there is only very [limited research evidence](#) for such lenses.

Over-sensitive- You could make changes to the [environment](#) such reducing fluorescent (strip) lighting, providing sunglasses. Avoid contrasting colours and patterns on your own clothing.

Smell



Under-sensitive- You could help by creating a routine around regular washing and using strong-smelling products to distract people from inappropriate strong-smelling stimuli (like faeces).

Over-sensitive- You could help by using unscented detergents or shampoos, avoiding wearing perfume, and making the environment as fragrance-free as possible.

Taste



Under or over-sensitive- Some autistic people may limit themselves to bland foods or crave very strong-tasting food. As long as someone has some dietary variety, this is not necessarily a problem. Find out more about [over-eating](#) and [restricted diets](#). You can offer new (healthy) foods such as fruit regularly, sometimes they might try it.

Balance (vestibular)



Under-sensitive- You could encourage activities that help to develop the vestibular system. This could include using swings, roundabouts, seesaws, catching a ball or practising walking smoothly up steps or curbs.

Over-sensitive- You could help by breaking down activities into small, more easily manageable steps and using visual cues such as a finish line.

Body awareness (proprioception)



Under-sensitive- You could help by:

- moving trip hazards out of the way to make navigation easier
- using weighted blankets to provide deep pressure
- using the 'arm's-length rule' to judge personal space - this means standing an arm's length away from other people.

Over-sensitive- You could help by offering 'fine motor' activities like lacing boards.

Interoception (internal state)



Under or over-sensitive- Trouble with interoception isn't as well-known as other sensory processing issues. Experts are still learning what techniques can help kids who struggle with it. Some experts think that mindfulness activities like meditation can help kids be more aware of interoceptive sensations in their bodies. "[Heavy work](#)" and a [sensory diet](#) may be helpful as well.